

The Rebate-Ready Garden

Lawn to Native Meadow Garden

Replace a patch of lawn with native flowers and grasses that bloom from spring to frost and never need mowing.

20 × 5 FEET · 46 PLANTS · FULL SUN · AVERAGE SOIL

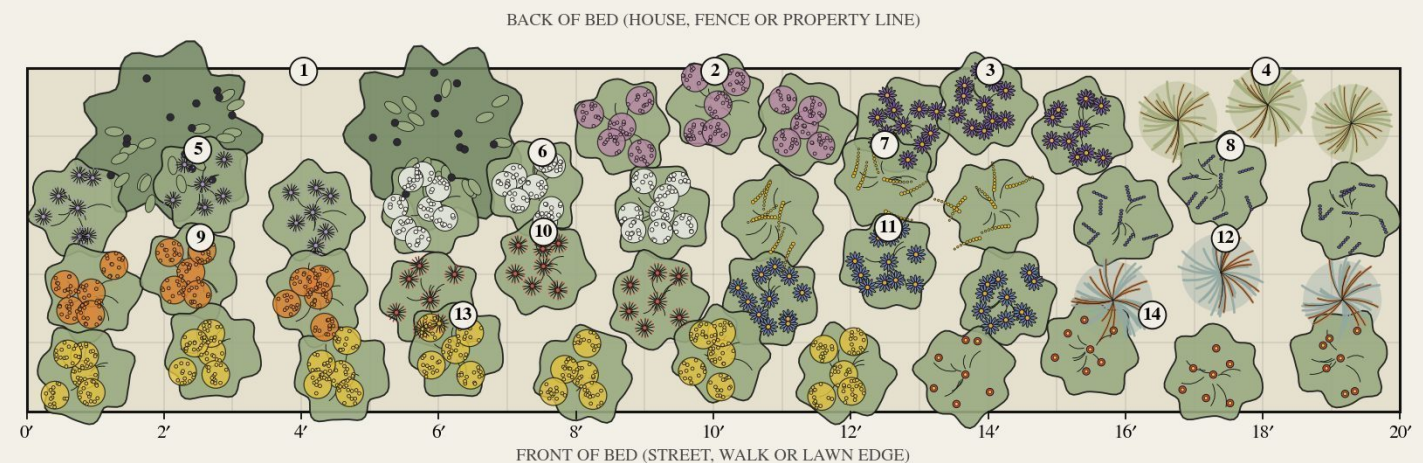


Fig. 1. The bed from above, to scale. Each grid square is one foot. Circled numbers match the list at right.

THE IDEA

This plan turns a rectangle of lawn into a bed of native flowers and grasses. Rebate programs call it conservation landscaping or native planting, and many of them pay homeowners back for doing it.

Everything here is native to New York. It blooms in waves: golden alexanders and columbine in spring, bergamot, butterfly weed and mountain mint in summer, then goldenrod and asters into October. Monarchs, bumblebees and goldfinches all use it.

Page 4 shows what the program pays and how this plan meets its rules. Page 5 is the plant list, laid out the way the application asks, plus the photo and step checklist.

Take the lawn out by smothering it with cardboard and mulch, or by cutting the sod. Don't start until your application is approved.

WHAT TO BUY

- ☐ 2 Black chokeberry
- ☐ 3 Spotted Joe-Pye weed
- ☐ 3 New England aster
- ☐ 3 Switchgrass
- ☐ 3 Wild bergamot
- ☐ 3 Virginia mountain mint
- ☐ 3 Showy goldenrod
- ☐ 3 Blue vervain
- ☐ 3 Butterfly weed
- ☐ 3 Scarlet bee balm
- ☐ 3 Smooth blue aster
- ☐ 3 Little bluestem
- ☐ 7 Golden alexanders
- ☐ 4 Wild columbine
- (1)
- (2)
- (3)
- (4)
- (5)
- (6)
- (7)
- (8)
- (9)
- (10)
- (11)
- (12)
- (13)
- (14)

46 plants in all. Buy quart pots (3-gallon for shrubs); the programs want real plants, not seed. Ask for the straight species, not a named cultivar.

The Rebate-Ready Garden

LONG ISLAND EDITION

HARDY IN ZONES 4-8 · PLAN NO. LI-15 · ORBITAL DESK LLC

PAGE 2 OF 5

The Bed at a Glance



Fig. 2. Each plant at its typical height, drawn in flower. They don't all bloom at once; page 3 shows when each one does.

Meet the Plants

1. Black chokeberry

Aronia melanocarpa · 3–6 ft · May–May

Berries for birds in winter. Brilliant red fall color; very adaptable.

2. Spotted Joe-Pye weed

Eutrochium maculatum · 4–6 ft · Jul–Sep

Swallowtails and bumblebees. Big back-of-border plant for moist spots.

3. New England aster

Symphotrichum novae-angliae · 3–6 ft · Aug–Oct

Late-season fuel for migrating monarchs. Pinch back in June for a shorter, bushier plant.

4. Switchgrass

Panicum virgatum · 3–6 ft · Jul–Sep

Seeds for birds. Tough screen; handles wet or dry.

5. Wild bergamot

Monarda fistulosa · 2–4 ft · Jul–Aug

Bumblebees and hummingbird moths. Tolerates drought once established.

6. Virginia mountain mint

Pycnanthemum virginianum · 2–3 ft · Jul–Sep

One of the best plants for pollinator variety. Minty leaves; deer tend to leave it alone.

7. Showy goldenrod

Solidago speciosa · 2–4 ft · Aug–Oct

Hundreds of insect species. Clump-forming; doesn't run like Canada goldenrod. Goldenrod doesn't cause hay fever.

8. Blue vervain

Verbena hastata · 2–5 ft · Jul–Sep

Bees; seeds feed birds. Tall candelabra spikes for wet meadows.

9. Butterfly weed

Asclepias tuberosa · 1–2.5 ft · Jun–Aug

Monarch caterpillar host. Deep taproot; hates being moved. Great for dry, sandy spots.

10. Scarlet bee balm

Monarda didyma · 2–4 ft · Jul–Aug

Hummingbirds. Wants steady moisture; powdery mildew if too dry.

11. Smooth blue aster

Symphotrichum laeve · 2–4 ft · Sep–Oct

Late-season bees. Tidier than New England aster; good in dry beds.

12. Little bluestem

Schizachyrium scoparium · 2–3 ft · Aug–Sep

Skipper butterfly host. Blue summer blades turn copper-orange in fall.

13. Golden alexanders

Zizia aurea · 1–3 ft · May–Jun

Black swallowtail caterpillar host. Early yellow when little else blooms.

14. Wild columbine

Aquilegia canadensis · 1–2 ft · Apr–Jun

Early hummingbirds. Thrives in rocky, thin soil.

Can't Find One?

Nurseries sell out by June. Any of these will fill the same spot:

Black chokeberry → Meadowsweet

Spotted Joe-Pye weed → Swamp milkweed

New England aster → Common milkweed

Switchgrass → Indian grass

Wild bergamot → Boneset

Virginia mountain mint → Great blue lobelia

Showy goldenrod → Black-eyed Susan

The Rebate-Ready Garden

What Blooms When

	JAN	FEB	MAR	APR	MAY	JUN	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV	DEC
1. Black chokeberry												
2. Spotted Joe-Pye weed												
3. New England aster												
4. Switchgrass												
5. Wild bergamot												
6. Virginia mountain mint												
7. Showy goldenrod												
8. Blue vervain												
9. Butterfly weed												
10. Scarlet bee balm												
11. Smooth blue aster												
12. Little bluestem												
13. Golden alexanders												
14. Wild columbine												

The Almanac: Looking After It

REMOVING THE LAWN

After approval, smother the grass with cardboard and 3–4 in of mulch for a few weeks, or cut the sod out. Call 811 before digging.

PLANTING

Plant in spring or early fall, straight through the mulch. Water every few days for the first month unless it rains.

THE FIRST YEAR

It'll look sparse. Pull weeds every two weeks; the plants fill in by year two.

MOWING

None. Cut the old stems to about a foot tall in late April and leave the stubs for nesting bees.

NEIGHBORS

A crisp edge (a stone border, a mown strip or a low fence) makes a meadow look intentional. Prince George's asks for one in front yards.

KEEP IT WORKING

The program expects you to maintain the garden. Keep your receipts and before-and-after photos together in one folder.

Your Notes

Date planted _____ Where the nursery was _____

The Rebate-Ready Garden

Your Rebate Packet

Nassau & Suffolk Counties, NY · rules checked Sept 30, 2026

WHAT THE PROGRAM PAYS

Reimburses plants and materials, at most \$500, if approved

Garden Rewards reimburses native plants, soil amendments, gravel and mulch with receipts; labor, tools, seed, shipping and tax don't count. North Hempstead reimburses native plants up to \$350. Cap: \$500 per property for Garden Rewards; \$350 in North Hempstead. Minimum size for this project: 50 sq ft. Programs covered: Long Island Garden Rewards (NEIWPCC), plus the Town of North Hempstead Native Plant Rebate. Who can apply: Nassau and Suffolk homeowners. North Hempstead residents use the town program; Peconic Estuary residents use the Peconic program.

THE RULES, AND HOW THIS PLAN MEETS THEM

Requirement	What the program asks	This plan
Minimum size	No minimum for Garden Rewards; 50 sq ft in North Hempstead	✓ 100 sq ft
Plants	Only species on the Long Island native plant list	✓ Every species checked against the 2025 list
Quantities	North Hempstead: at least 3 of each herbaceous species	✓ 3 or more of each species
Proof	Receipts and photos	✓ Photo checklist on page 5

MEASURING THE AREA

The rebate reimburses what you spend on native plants and materials, so the bed size mostly sets your plant budget. Stake out the bed ($20 \times 5 \text{ ft} = 100 \text{ sq ft}$), take your 'before' photos with the stakes in, and keep them. A curved edge is fine; keep the same area.

THE SKETCH

Fig. 1 on page 1 is drawn to scale with every plant placed. On a copy, sketch in your house, driveway and any trees near the bed, and write in the distances. That, plus the plant list on page 5, is the planting plan the application asks for.

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PAGE 5 OF 5

Submission Sheet

The plant list, laid out the way the application asks for it. Attach it with Fig. 1.

#	Common name	Scientific name	Container	Qty	Spacing	Native
1	Black chokeberry	<i>Aronia melanocarpa</i>	3 gal	2	48 in	NY
2	Spotted Joe-Pye weed	<i>Eutrochium maculatum</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
3	New England aster	<i>Symphyotrichum novae-angliae</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
4	Switchgrass	<i>Panicum virgatum</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
5	Wild bergamot	<i>Monarda fistulosa</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
6	Virginia mountain mint	<i>Pycnanthemum virginianum</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
7	Showy goldenrod	<i>Solidago speciosa</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
8	Blue vervain	<i>Verbena hastata</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
9	Butterfly weed	<i>Asclepias tuberosa</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
10	Scarlet bee balm	<i>Monarda didyma</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
11	Smooth blue aster	<i>Symphyotrichum laeve</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
12	Little bluestem	<i>Schizachyrium scoparium</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
13	Golden alexanders	<i>Zizia aurea</i>	Quart	7	18 in	NY
14	Wild columbine	<i>Aquilegia canadensis</i>	Quart	4	18 in	NY

46 plants · 20 × 5 ft = 100 sq ft · 100% native to New York (USDA PLANTS) and on the Long Island native list · no cultivars needed

Mulch: about 1.0 cubic yards at 3 in.

STEP BY STEP

- ☐ Check which program you're in: Garden Rewards, North Hempstead, or Peconic Estuary.
- ☐ North Hempstead: apply BEFORE you buy, with the size, species list, layout, photos and budget. Garden Rewards: no pre-approval.
- ☐ Buy only listed native species (this plan's list qualifies). Keep every receipt and ask for itemized ones.
- ☐ Call 811 before digging.
- ☐ Build it and take the photos on this page.
- ☐ Submit the reimbursement form with receipts and photos (Garden Rewards fall round: by Oct 31 or until funds run out).
- ☐ Keep the garden up for at least 3 years; Garden Rewards expects it.

PHOTOS TO TAKE

- ☐ The spot before you start
- ☐ Planting day
- ☐ The finished garden
- ☐ Each plant with its tag or labeled pot
- ☐ Your receipts laid out

KEEP IN ONE FOLDER

Every itemized receipt (plants, soil amendments, mulch), your photos, any approval, and this packet.

SOURCES

neiwpcc.org Long Island Garden Rewards page (updated 9/1/26) and FAQ; NYFA Long Island Native Plants list (generated 4/1/25); Town of North Hempstead 2026 Native Plant Rebate terms.